Sher Afghan Asad

Economic Consultant — Public Finance, Tax Policy & State Capacity

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Professional Profile

Economist with extensive experience supporting international development partners, bilateral donors, and government counterparts on **tax policy, revenue administration, and market regulation**, with research published in leading peer-reviewed journals. Strong expertise in translating administrative data and field evidence into **operational policy recommendations**. Proven track record working directly with tax authorities on reform design, pilot implementation, and evaluation in low- and middle-income countries.

Core Expertise

- Tax Policy and Revenue Administration
- Behavioral and Enforcement-Based Compliance Strategies
- Property Taxation and Valuation Reform
- Informality, Firm Behavior, and Market Competition
- Distributional and Fiscal Incidence Analysis
- Impact Evaluation and Administrative Data Systems

Sectors and Geographic Experience

Sectors: Tax policy and administration; local public finance; property taxation; value added tax (VAT); digital public infrastructure; invoice monitoring; market regulation; gender and taxation.

Regions: South Asia (Pakistan, Sri Lanka); South America (Argentina); Low- and middle-income countries.

Selected Consultancy and Policy Experience

Asian Development Bank (ADB) *2026–Present*
Gender and Public Finance Specialist

- Leading **gender integration** in the design of a major ADB-financed **tax administration digitalization program**, working directly with the national revenue authority.
- Preparing the program's **Gender Assessment and Action Plan (GAAP)** and **inclusive digital service design recommendations** for taxpayer and customs systems; contributing to feasibility study, due diligence, and Board documents.
- Authoring a commissioned paper on **gender and taxation** for ADB's **Country Gender Assessment**, informing the Country Partnership Strategy and planned as an ADB knowledge product.

World Bank Group *2024–2025*
Short-Term Consultant, Poverty & Equity Global Practice (South Asia)

- Conducted **distributional and fiscal incidence analysis** for Sri Lanka's *Country Climate and Development Report (CCDR)* and *Public Finance Review*.
- Assessed equity impacts of climate shocks and tax reforms using CEQ methods, household surveys, and geospatial data.
- Provided analytical inputs informing policy dialogue on revenue mobilization and climate adaptation.

GIZ (Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit) *2023–2025*
International Consultant — Property Tax Reform and Local Public Finance

- Advised and supported implementation of the transition from **rental-value assessments to a market-value property tax system**, facilitating modernization of sub-national property taxation.
- Coordinated an **inter-agency working group on property taxation**, bringing together tax authorities, municipalities, other governmental departments, and planning agencies to strengthen coordination.
- Supported integration of **land, cadastral, and taxpayer data systems** to improve valuation accuracy and administrative effectiveness.
- Facilitated **technical sessions and capacity-building workshops** with senior officials and field staff to support reform rollout.

Adam Smith International (FCDO – SEED Programme) *2023–2024*
Advisor

- Led design and analysis of a **policy pilot combining behavioral nudges and enforcement** to improve tax compliance in the hospitality sector.
- Worked with tax authorities to integrate experimental insights into operational enforcement strategies.

British High Commission / REMIT Programme *2022*
Program Consultant

- Led stakeholder consultations and policy workshops on tax reform and private-sector engagement.
- Developed tax reform recommendations informing inputs to the federal annual budget process.

Selected Policy-Relevant Research Projects

- **Artificial Intelligence and Property Tax Reform** Examines the use of *computer vision and machine-learning tools* to strengthen property tax administration. Evaluates how algorithmic property valuations compare with traditional inspector assessments, and whether AI-assisted targeting can improve equity, transparency, and local revenue performance in low-capacity settings.
- **Informality Traps and Tax Enforcement** Studies why firms remain persistently informal despite enforcement efforts, and whether regulatory and tax enforcement can unintentionally lock markets into *low-compliance equilibria*. Combines administrative tax data with field experiments to assess how enforcement intensity, monitoring technologies, and market structure shape firm entry, exit, and formalization dynamics.
- **Consumer Incentives and Tax Compliance: Receipt Lottery Experiment** Designed and evaluated, with the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Revenue Authority, the first field experiment to randomize which firms' receipts qualify for a *consumer receipt lottery*, cross-randomized with the authority's own enforcement letters. Consumers took part and many of their receipts recorded sales missing from the authority's records, yet firms' tax declarations did not change, as the authority rarely acted on the receipts. In response, the province amended its sales tax law to let the government prescribe how consumer receipts are verified.
- **Digital Invoice Monitoring and Real-Time Compliance** Evaluates the rollout of *electronic invoice monitoring systems* that transmit transaction data directly to the tax authority in real time. Assesses impacts on reported sales, tax remittances, firm behavior, and the operational challenges of scaling digital tax infrastructure in developing economies. Findings are under revision for resubmission at the *Journal of Public Economics*.

Selected Academic Publications (Policy-Relevant)

- **Asad, S.A.** (2025). *Taxation in Pakistan: Challenges, Reforms, and the Case for a Scientific Approach*. In R. Pande (Ed.), *Routledge Handbook of Contemporary Pakistan. Policy-oriented synthesis of Pakistan's tax system, reform constraints, and evidence-based proposals to strengthen revenue capacity and governance.*
- **Asad, S.A., Ahmad, H.F., & Majid, H.** (2025). *Price and Prejudice: Gender Discrimination in Online Marketplaces*. Journal of Development Economics.
  Uses experimental and platform data to identify non-price discrimination affecting women's participation in digital markets.
- **Asad, S.A., Banerjee, R., & Bhattacharya, J.** (2023). *Do Workers Discriminate Against Their Out-Group Employers? Evidence from an Online Platform Economy*. Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization.
  Demonstrates how social identity shapes market interactions, with implications for labor market efficiency and inclusion.

Academic Appointments and Affiliations

Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS)
Assistant Professor of Economics *2020–Present*

Iowa State University
Visiting Assistant Professor of Economics *2024–2025*

Affiliations: J-PAL Invited Researcher; Research Affiliate, International Growth Centre (IGC); Weiss Fund Grantee; Director, Public Finance Research Cluster, Mahbub ul Haq Research Centre.

Education

Ph.D. in Economics — Iowa State University *2015–2020*
Fulbright Scholar

M.Sc. in Economics — Lahore University of Management Sciences *2010–2011*

B.Sc. (Hons.) in Economics — Forman Christian College *2006–2010*
Gold Medalist

Selected Clients and Partners

Asian Development Bank • World Bank Group • GIZ • FCDO • British High Commission • Provincial Revenue Authorities (Pakistan) • International Growth Centre • J-PAL • PEDL

Technical Skills

Stata • R • Python • SQL • ArcGIS • Econometric & Spatial Analysis • Policy Reporting

Languages

English (Fluent) • Urdu (Native) • Punjabi (Fluent)

References available upon request